The Emotionally Intelligent Leader - Study guide

Leader course | Trainer: Maya Thompson

About this guide

Shape the emotional climate of your organisation and lead others through pressure.

These notes follow the video lecture for this course. Read them before or after watching, and use them to revise before the final quiz.

What you will be able to do

- Read and shape team climate deliberately

- Model calm under organisational pressure

- Coach managers to grow their own EI

Leaders set the weather

- Your mood spreads through the team

- People read you closely

- Climate affects performance

Welcome to The Emotionally Intelligent Leader. A leader’s mood tends to spread through a team. People watch how you react to news, how you handle pressure, and whether you listen. Researchers describe this as the leader setting the weather. A tense leader creates a tense team, and a steady leader makes it easier for others to think clearly. This lecture covers how to read and shape the climate of your team deliberately, how to stay calm under organisational pressure, and how to coach other managers to grow their own emotional intelligence.

Reading the climate of a team

- Listen to what is not being said

- Watch energy across the week

- Ask people directly, and often

Before you can shape the climate, you need to read it. Listen to what is not being said, such as the topics people avoid. Watch the energy across the week. When does it rise, and when does it fall. Ask people directly, in one to ones and in small groups,

how things feel. Short pulse questions help, as long as you act on the answers. Keep in mind that people tell leaders less than they tell each other. So the picture you see is usually more positive than the reality. Make it easy and safe to tell you the truth.

Shaping the climate on purpose

- Decide the tone you want

- Show it in small behaviours

- Repeat it consistently

Once you can read the climate, decide what you want it to be, such as open, focused and calm. Then show it in small behaviours. How you start meetings, how you respond to bad news, how you thank people. Small, repeated actions shape culture more than speeches. Consistency matters, because people notice when words and behaviour differ. If you say you value candour, but react badly when someone disagrees, they will believe your reaction. Aim to be predictable in the ways that matter, so people feel safe around you.

Leading under pressure

- Pressure travels downward

- Pause before you pass it on

- Say what you know and what you do not

Pressure on a leader travels downward. If you pass on urgency without thinking, it becomes anxiety for others. Before you communicate a difficult message, pause. Ask what the team needs to know, and what is still uncertain. Then be honest about both. Saying, here is what I know, here is what I do not know yet, and here is when I will update you, creates steadiness. People cope better with uncertainty than with silence. Look after your own recovery too, because a depleted leader has less to give.

Making it safe to speak up

- Thank people who bring bad news

- Respond to ideas with curiosity

- Admit your own mistakes

Teams perform better when people can speak up. You create that safety through your reactions. Thank people who bring bad news, even if you do not like it. Respond to ideas with curiosity, by asking questions before judging. And admit your own mistakes openly, which shows that errors can be discussed. When a leader says, I got that wrong, here is what I learned, it gives permission to others. Safety is built slowly through many small responses, and it can be damaged quickly by one careless reaction, so stay aware.

Growing emotional intelligence in your managers

- Coach in one to ones, not memos

- Ask questions that build awareness

- Give feedback on how they lead

If you lead managers, your impact multiplies through them. Emotional intelligence grows best through coaching, not through a memo or an annual test. Use your one to ones with managers to ask questions that build awareness. How do you think the team experienced that meeting. What did you notice in yourself. Give specific feedback on how they lead, including the effect on their team. Model the behaviour yourself, since managers copy what leaders do. Encourage them to practise in small moments, and to reflect on them regularly.

Your own development as a leader

- Ask for honest feedback

- Notice your patterns under stress

- Build a reflection habit

Leaders need development too, and often get less feedback as they become more senior. Ask for honest feedback from people you trust, and make it clear that you want the truth. Notice your own patterns under stress, such as becoming controlling or withdrawn. A short reflection habit helps. At the end of each week, note one moment you handled well, and one you would handle differently. Over time, this builds the

self-awareness that everything else depends on. The best leaders stay curious about their own impact.

Your next steps

- Choose one climate behaviour to model

- Plan one coaching question per manager

- Complete the workbook and the final quiz

To finish, choose one behaviour that you will model consistently this month, such as how you open meetings. Write one coaching question for each manager who reports to you. Complete the workbook for this course, which includes a climate check and a reflection log. Then take the final quiz. When you reach the end of the last lesson, you will receive your certificate and a personal review of how you worked through the course. Thank you for listening, and good luck leading with awareness.

Glossary

Team climate: The shared feeling in a team that shapes how safe and energised people are at work.

Pulse question: A short, frequent question used to read how the team is feeling.

Coaching: Helping someone build their own awareness and skill through questions and feedback.

Modelling: Showing through your own behaviour the standard you expect from others.